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Leslie Johnson

Leslie Johnson is an ardent supporter of traditional jazz and has been the editor of The Mississippi Rag *for 33 years. She chaired a panel at the 2007 IAJE conference that addressed the current status of traditional jazz in music education and the marketplace.*

Leslie was interviewed in New York City on January 12, 2007 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in Manhattan at the IAJE. I'm pleased to have Leslie Johnson, editor of *The Mississippi Rag* with me. And this is — we've had a long list of interviewees but you are our first editor of a publication.

LJ: So you've done just musicians up to this point?

MR: We've done mostly musicians, we've done some authors and critics, and publicists type of thing. But I thought you did a good job this morning with your panel. I'm wondering if the title they thought of for you is true in your mind, which I should say was —

LJ: It was called "Still Swinging: Trad Jazz is Alive and Well." And I would have said trad jazz is alive but struggling because the audience is getting older and we have to expand the audience and we really have to use the Internet I think to do that. And jazz educators need to be educated about traditional jazz and its value. I think that's really the key. Because if the educators don't know anything about the early music they can't teach it, and you get farther and farther and farther and farther away from the roots of the music and they're starting much farther down the line without really understanding the value of the fundamentals of jazz. Or, the other thing is, the history is so rich with characters. And the music is so varied that they're really missing an opportunity I think to show how much it's influenced our culture, how jazz has just — the language, the clothing, it's really intermeshed with so many things that we just take for granted now but it really goes back to the beginnings of jazz.

MR: Wouldn't it be great if American history classes taught about it? Because it doesn't have to just be compartmentalized into a music class. It's a part of our culture.

LJ: Did you ever hear about the Milwaukee Jazz Experience?

MR: No I guess not.

LJ: It was something that was started by a guy named John Bartles in Milwaukee. And it was — I want to say it was the late seventies, maybe '78 or so, '79. And John really had a vision that was exactly what you're talking about. And he put on two — I believe it was two events — called the Milwaukee Jazz Experience. And I participated in it and Butch Thompson participated in it, a guy named Reggie Buckner who was the head of jazz

studies at the University of Minnesota was part of it, and what John accomplished is he got the superintendent of schools in Milwaukee to cooperate with him and they — and the *Milwaukee Journal* — for a whole year they prepared kids for the Milwaukee Jazz Experience which happened — it was still during the school year, the end of the school year. And the *Milwaukee Journal* published tabloids, not real thick, but tabloids about — it had a timeline, a historical timeline of jazz, and it had capsule histories of the important people in jazz. They also published flash cards of jazz personalities, just like a baseball card, that were used in classes, and they built a curriculum, John and the teachers built a curriculum where it was part of English, it was part of art, it was part of the music class, it was part of the social studies class, and it covered K through 12. Then for the Milwaukee Jazz Experience they bussed kids in from the local schools to — I believe it was Viterbo College, was that the one? I can't remember what the college was, it was a Catholic College and it had agreed to participate. And they turned over the whole campus to this Milwaukee Jazz Experience and it was very much of a budgeted sort of thing and people paid their own way to come there to participate in it. The clinicians didn't get paid or anything. But they came in and they gave seminars. But the thing was the kids came to the concerts and they already knew something about the music because they'd been prepared or a whole year with these written materials and with the classroom curriculum. So for instance Butch Thompson did a whole section, he did a very good concert on the blues. And he just talked to the kids. And he mentioned how the blues came about, and played a little bit and talked about the different musicians and how they differed. But the kids could ask intelligent questions. It was a wonderful project. John did it for two years and then he unfortunately died of a heart attack and things just kind of fell apart. The superintendent moved on, the *Milwaukee Journal* people who were there, I believe Kevin Whitehead was at the *Milwaukee Journal* at that time and he'd be a good person to ask about this. Because he was very much involved in preparing some of the written materials and covering the Milwaukee Jazz Experience. It was a very ambitious project and it was head and shoulders and way ahead of the curve as far as any of this jazz curriculum thing is concerned. I'm so excited about what Dave Robinson is doing because that's actually the sort of thing that John was trying to accomplish, to bring it into the schools for kids much younger. Because if you can get the kids who are young, they really respond to the music, to the early music. They're very enthused about it. But if they get to be in high school you really have pretty much lost them.

MR: Oh yeah. Right. 'Cause young kids won't be — I mean I think sometimes the problem with presenting this music is the audio quality of some of the original recordings. It just sounds too different to their ears.

LJ: Old timey.

MR: But little kids will not be deterred by that so much.

LJ: Um hum. They respond to the rhythm of it.

MR: And they get a kick out of if you play records for them, you know that whole — they're more easily reached I think.

LJ: Well you can dance to it.

MR: Yeah.

LJ: That's what I think the appeal is that it has a quality that just draws you in and it energizes you. I think that's the thing that I really love about traditional jazz and early music. And when I would go down to New Orleans and be at Preservation Hall for instance, we would stay up all night of course at jam sessions. But the music was so energizing that you didn't get tired. You'd go all night and then the next night go all night. But the music just had such vitality. And that, I can remember first hearing it when I was a little kid and it had that quality for me as a six and seven year old child. I distinctly remember hearing certain tunes by Kid Ory and certain tunes by Duke Ellington, and dancing. And that was my response.

MR: Were your parents — were they into it or not?

LJ: No. Not at all. Not at all. My mother loved music but it was more classical, and she wasn't all that tuned into it, although she became quite a jazz fan as I got involved in it and went to New Orleans and really did the whole bit, and was reasonably knowledgeable about it and my family sort of came into it. But no it wasn't a family that was oriented around music.

MR: Where did you hear it then?

LJ: I just heard it on the radio. It was played on — there was a local DJ who liked early jazz, although at that time it wasn't as early as it is now. There were still players around like Red Allen, I mean we're talking about the forties and fifties. So it was still on the radio.

MR: Do you remember the first time that you saw a really good jazz band live?

LJ: I honestly did not see a jazz band live until I was an adult, and it was at the Emporium of Jazz in Mendota, which was the jazz mecca for the Twin Cities. And I remember going out and seeing Max Morath play out there, who has become an extremely close friend, a dear, dear man. Max is just a phenomenon as far as I'm concerned, there's nobody like Max. I would love to see him here at IAJE doing a talk on Ragtime and popular culture. He is absolutely the ultimate entertainer. There is no one comes close to Max as far as I'm concerned.

MR: Where does he live?

LJ: Well now he is living in Duluth, Minnesota because he married a woman who works for the University of Minnesota as, I believe it's the development director, his second wife. He had lived in New York up until maybe five — oh gee he's been married to Diane

longer than that although they lived in New York up until probably about five years ago. She had worked for the U prior to that and then they got married and they moved here and then the University up in Duluth, that particular branch, offered her a good job because she's really good at what she does. And she took it.

MR: Well maybe Tim and I will have to go to Duluth.

LJ: Max is wonderful. He comes to New York every once in a while.

MR: Well in thinking about this morning, people like to say why do we have to have categories. I mean it's easy to say that. But in reality, don't you have to —

LJ: You have to define the terms.

MR: You have to define somehow. I mean Arbors, his brochure says classic jazz and that gives you some information. But you can't publish a paper called *The Rag*.

LJ: You have to define it and you have to respect the various genres too. That's the other part of it. I think I agree with Mat when he says it's all good music. But you don't sell it based on it's all good music. In the same, Wycliffe saying can't it all be considered jazz, but it really can't because people have their favorites and they have their favorite genre and they're so different. They all fall under the umbrella of improvisation up to a point until you get into the really arranged materials that you get in college. But the earlier jazz, it's improvisation. In Ragtime there's a big deal, there's classic rag and there's folk rag, that there's a real division of if you play folk rag, if you play classic ragtime, tell me if you play classic ragtime and you're playing just the notes exactly as the composer wrote it, there's no improvisation whatsoever. Folk ragtime is far more lilting. It has more of a rolling quality to the music and it's more improvisational. People who — I'll give you an example of Bob Milne is a very good ragtime player and he improvises all over the place and he wrote a book called *The Journeyman Piano Player* about what it was like, and he still does this, traveling all over —

MR: Was he on Lawrence Welk?

LJ: No, no. Ut uh.

MR: Bob Milne?

LJ: Yeah. M-I-L-N-E.

MR: All right. Never mind.

LJ: He lives in Michigan, but he's hardly ever there, he's all over the place. And he says heck the classical composers improvised, Ragtimers improvise, so there's kind of a conflict there although it's become much less than it used to be. But I would say maybe ten years ago that was a hot topic in the very tight community.

MR: Yeah that's so interesting you know.

LJ: So even within the genre there's infighting.

MR: Yeah. And someone used the word this morning, "Bixophiles."

LJ: I used that.

MR: Did you use that? That is so interesting. I mean there are just people who are crazy about every darn thing you can think of. And that's sort of what your market is, right?

LJ: Well that's right. And really the challenge was, when I started the paper, was okay folks, you have to cooperate if you want to have your own publication. Because there had been other publications that had started and the purists said well unless you only do it about George Lewis I'm not buying that publication. Unless you only do it about Bunk Johnson, I don't have any time for it. Because they were so passionate about their particular musician. But nobody could exist as a publication. So my very first editorial said you're going to have to trust me that I will try and cover whomever it is that you're interested in, but you're going to have to wait and you're going to have to read other stuff. And to their credit they did, and they have remained — I can't tell you how many subscribers I have who have every single issue of *The Rag*. Every single issue, which astounded me when that first started happening, you know, after the first year and I discovered that, you know it's a tabloid in newsprint and I thought well they'll read it and throw it away. No. They've kept them. Now as they've gotten older they're having to downsize and they call up and they say, "I have 33 years worth of 'Rags,' I can't bear to throw them out or recycle them, what can I do with them?" And I'll say donate them to a music library or take them to a nursing home or give them to a music school. Because they just cannot stand to part with them. It's really very, very sweet. But they did pay attention to that first editorial and honestly, that was like a mission statement and I really have not ever deviated from that over all this time. *The Rag* covers the whole spectrum of traditional jazz. And I do like the term traditional jazz, I don't like the term Dixieland.

MR: What about the term trad jazz?

LJ: Well trad jazz — it's fine. You know it's just a shortcut. And there's nothing wrong with that except some people think of it as being British. I don't.

MR: Oh someone else mentioned that, okay.

LJ: I don't think of it as that, I just think of it as a shortcut for traditional jazz.

MR: Okay. I guess — maybe it's things I've seen at some of the festivals, something about just saying "trad" makes me more likely to think of just the arm garters and the outfits.

LJ: The white belts and the striped shirts and the straw hats.

MR: Now do you think that picture in your mind makes it harder to promote this music?

LJ: Yeah. The tricky part of this is Dixieland was actually a fine term way back when both black and white bands used that term. It wasn't just a white band that used the term Dixieland, a lot of the black bands did use it. Kid Thomas I believe, he had a band that he called the Dixieland band, the Kid Thomas Dixieland Band. That was not a bad word. What happened was it became more of associated with the novelty music or ice cream

social type music rather than serious improvisational jazz. It became a music where the solo was passed around rather than ensembling. And that, you just change the whole meaning of that word. And what you have, quite frankly, were people that formed a Dixieland band who could only play a little, not a lot. And so it took on a bad connotation where there were some musicians who didn't want to be associated with that word at all, you'd never use that word around Wild Bill Davison for instance. Oh my goodness. He did not want to be considered a Dixieland player. So, but the tricky thing is there are some very good festivals who incorporate that word into their title. There are also some bands who are very good who use that word, or say they play Dixieland, and you don't want to insult them and say, mmm, not a good word, because they're actually good musicians. But if people ask me, oh do you cover Dixieland music I say well we like to call it classic jazz or early jazz or traditional jazz because it covers more than what would be considered Dixieland. Because I think that's a very — people have a very closed idea of what that music is. If they think that's all traditional jazz is that's a mistake.

MR: Is the word "Dixie" in itself problematic?

LJ: No. I don't think that that's it. I think it's really the image of the ice cream social. And I think that that's the concept that a lot of jazz educators have, is that they're going to lump it all into Dixieland and they don't see the scope of the music.

MR: Right. And I bet, I don't think that there's an awful lot of people around who don't consider jazz to be an art form, a legitimate art form, I think that's been pretty much accepted. But I would agree with you that educators might not think of Dixieland as an art form so much or it's just not — it doesn't have enough weight to it.

LJ: It doesn't have any heft.

MR: It doesn't have any heft.

LJ: It doesn't. And what they'll do is, a jazz studies program will bring in somebody like Butch Thompson or somebody who has somewhat of a name locally, they'll bring in a local artist who is involved with traditional jazz and they'll say we're going to cover Dixieland, you know, we're doing the history part of the jazz studies program, would you come in and do an hour on Dixieland. And that's it. Butch will go in and he'll do the hour. He won't call it Dixieland, he'll talk about early jazz. But if jazz studies even does that. The trick is, I don't think that they're even doing it as much as they did before. And the materials haven't been there. So you have jazz educators who don't treat the music with respect and so they don't learn about it, they aren't stimulated by it. The value of the Ken Burns series was it did bring it to the forefront. There was a lot of controversy about it and I had some real problems with that series. But nevertheless it was treated with some respect and audiences heard the music for the first time. And I thought there was way too much social commentary in it, and I saw it as being divisive and polarizing

rather than having what I consider to be the heart of jazz which is that you bring all sorts of people and races together in the music. I think it has a very healing quality rather than a polarizing quality and that was my main complaint with his series.

MR: Why don't you see — there's very few black musicians who seem to play in early jazz bands, in traditional jazz bands, at least in my experience.

LJ: That's true. In ragtime there's a fellow who got a MacArthur grant, Reginald Robinson — are you familiar with Reggie?

MR: No.

LJ: He is a young black man who heard Scott Joplin recordings. He was 13 years old. Reginald was 13 years old, a Chicago guy. He taught himself how to do fingering to play ragtime and he's really a genius. He taught himself how to play, Bob Koester from Delmark Records heard about him and took him under his wing. Reginald went to — I'm not sure what the music school was — and the teacher there said he does the fingering right, which was astonishing.

MR: Because he taught himself.

LJ: He's taught himself. He composes Ragtime that is so difficult to play it's amazing. He really is, it really is a genius grant in his case. And I think he must be maybe — at the time that he really emerged he was only 18 I believe, and that was maybe ten years ago. So he's possibly he's 30 now and he got the grant maybe four years ago I think. But he's one of the few in ragtime. There are a couple of other black musicians in ragtime. In the traditional jazz world there are very few and I think that that's because in the black community the musicians tend to go for the cutting edge. They're always looking for something different rather than going back and playing the music that's been played before. I think they tend to be innovators. And so I think that they're always looking ahead rather than looking back. I feel badly that they don't appreciate the tremendous history and in some cases they thought of it as Uncle Tom music because it was black bands playing for white audiences but having to come in the back door. So they didn't want anything to do with it. I do think that it's very healthy that Wynton Marsalis has said hey this is worth pursuing and worth learning about. I think he's been very good for the music in that sense and helping the black community realize that there's value in that history. So I really give him credit for that.

MR: Good. What's the — prioritize the, not problems, the issues, with doing your newspaper. I thought — I knew that would get a little bit of a groan.

LJ: It's a lot of work and there's no money in it. I mean that's — but for anybody who's in traditional jazz there's no money in it. The festivals are lucky if they break even. Nobody makes any money on it. The main problem is you're trying to satisfy a lot of different tastes, you're trying to satisfy an audience who is aging and the audience is dwindling, so

the challenge is trying to bring in new people. There is no interest on the part of the press. The general press has no interest in traditional jazz. And the rare times that they're kind of forced into doing an article, the articles are rife with errors. And it's almost more frustrating to have an article published with the errors than it is to not have an article at all. It just makes you want to tear out your hair, really. That's one of the problems. Because you're serving a small audience it's expensive to publish a paper like mine. From the very first issue I paid my writers, which most traditional jazz publications never did. I paid them a pittance. But on the other hand because *The Rag* is respected they can build a reputation because I will work with writers to refine their writing skills, to help them make contacts, to give them access to musicians that they wouldn't have access to. Chip Deffaa, you probably know Chip, he — every book that he writes, he writes something and he says you gave me my start, which is very sweet but it's also very true. Because he's written, put together, I believe it's four books based on interviews that were first published in *The Mississippi Rag*. And they're expanded interviews. I edited them down and, quite honestly, I think the edited versions are stronger, but he naturally had more material that he wanted to include. You know, he wanted to include the full interview. And the books are, I'm very glad that he had the books published, but I helped him to find the publishers. I could say you're not going to like this publisher, they won't work with you or they're going to expect you to do more work or you're going to end up putting out money and, you know, try this person instead. And so he's done that and it's worked out quite nicely for him. And he's built up a good reputation. I think he got his job at the *New York Post* based largely on the access that he had to the musicians where we ran interviews in *The Rag*.

MR: When you look ahead at your upcoming year and your issues, how do you decide what to focus on and who to ask for articles? Do you call writers and say we need — it's time for an article about Marty Grosz, or how does that work?

LJ: I always have more material than I have space for. That has always been the case. So it's a matter of going through what I have on hand or what I know people are working on and determining what the balance is going to be. In each issue I try and have an historical article, some ragtime feature, some festival feature, and we have regional columns always, and then reviews. One of the most popular things that we run is called "Ragtime Machine" and it's transcriptions of interviews that David Rafkin has done at the University of San Francisco. He has a radio show called "The Ragtime Machine" and he interviews all kinds of ragtime people, some jazz people, and sends me the transcriptions and we run those because the University of San Francisco has a very limited listening audience. And that's a very popular feature. The historical features, somebody, those are generated sometimes by me where I have a writer where I think that writer might have

access to somebody or I know they have a particular interest. Otherwise, now for instance David French had written to me and he kind of came out of the woodwork. I didn't know about him at all but he wanted to do a piece on Ziggy Elman. And I thought well okay. And so we talked and he turned in the initial few pages and I thought well that's pretty interesting and he's a good writer. So we worked together and then published that story, and now David is writing the New York column for me and he really is a wonderful writer and a wonderful guy. So we've built up that relationship. With Chip, I'm trying to think of the first article that Chip did for me, and I honestly can't remember at this point because it's so many years ago. But I told him that I'd always wanted an article on Sam Wooding, and so he — and I can't remember, and there again we're going back years and years and years, I can't remember who I had access to, but I put Chip on to that person and eventually we did run a two part interview with Sam Wooding that ended up in one of Chip's books. And he formed a friendship with the family where when Sam Wooding was dying Chip literally did his last interviewing of him, pretty much even when Sam Wooding was on his death bed. I mean it's quite a story. I ran a story this last summer that had been six years in the making on Thelma Terry, and that was a fellow who was really enamored with her and very little was known about her. The fellow who wrote it is a philosophy professor in Minneapolis. And he said, "Are you interested in a story on Thelma Terry?" Well he and I both worked with Thelma's family. He had rounded up her family in Michigan and we went to Michigan, he got them to part with some photos from the scrapbook, they didn't know very much about her. And it took six years before we actually got it in print, and I ran it as a two part story and it really turned out fantastically well. And in fact when I saw Dan Morgenstern this last summer he came up to me and said, "Thank you for running the story on Thelma Terry I always wanted to know about her."

MR: Oh that's great.

LJ: So I thought that was the ultimate compliment.

MR: Do you have — I know that major newspapers often times have obituaries ready.

LJ: No, I don't.

MR: I'm glad. It's like I know they sort of have to.

LJ: No, I know, it's kind of morbid. No we don't. But I have enough material on them where — what I try and do is interview them before they die. Because for one thing they get so many letters and phone calls from people once we've run the article that it's such a boon to these older musicians to have the article published while they're alive. And sometimes it's such a race against the clock. But I can't tell you how many musicians have said, "I've heard from nephews that I haven't known anything that they were even around." Or I've had family members call up and say I heard that you did an article on my uncle or

on my grandfather or on this old college friend, can you give me his address. And then they're in contact. In fact in the *Grove Dictionary of Jazz The Rag* is used as a reference for a lot of the biographies. And I will hear from somebody who's read about their grandfather or father or uncle or aunt or — in the *Grove Dictionary* and then they see that there's a reference to an article and they'll call and they'll say do you have that back issue available, which I may or may not have.

MR: Somebody has it, right?

LJ: Well somebody has it. I do have maybe one or two copies of some of the early issues and more copies — and once I found out that people saved them or that new subscribers would order back issues like you can't believe, then I would have a press overrun so that I could sell these back issues. So very often I can provide it. But they'll say, "I didn't know anything except that my grandfather was a musician and reading that little bio, now I know something about him and you ran a long article on him."

MR: That's great.

LJ: Yeah. It is very rewarding to be able to do that.

MR: It must have been a major decision to go to on-line publication. Is that something you had prepared for or thought about for a long time?

LJ: Well I had been thinking about it for probably a year and a half and I had already introduced the subject to my readers who went [gasp] no, no, don't do it.

MR: Right.

LJ: Because they were older subscribers and they were kind of scared of the whole idea and they didn't understand — they liked having a print paper. And I like having a print paper. You know my own preference is to have a print paper. But as a small publication's editor I have had so many problems with the post office because of lost issues which have to be replaced at first class rates, you know. So if they screwed up a delivery or damaged it or had late delivery, which happened time after time where people would call up and it would be the 15th of the month and they'd eventually — I mean I would publish on the 21st of the month with the idea hopefully that they would get it by the first of the month. A lot of people wouldn't get it until the 15th, maybe the 20th. And they would call up and say I didn't get it. So I would send out a duplicate issue at first class rates and they would get two, that's right. The interesting thing is very often they'd get the two on the same day. Now what does that tell you? It tells you that the post office, the carrier was either sitting on it or, in many cases, reading it. Because when they would get the first one the tab would be broken. I cannot tell you how often that happened. And so it cost a fortune to be replacing these issues, plus the international mail is a tremendous headache to prepare. I knew more about the mailing requirements than the post office did so in some cases I would have to take the pages from the international mail manual with me when I

would bring the bags of international mail, and say no, this is really the way periodicals postage is supposed to be prepared and sent. This is how the tags have to be. Just a tremendous amount of work. And then paper prices keep going up. So there was that. And then I had some health problems where I thought okay I'm just going to tell the subscribers I can't do these all-nighters again and again and again and again. So once I told them that they said oh, we love you, see?

MR: They could relate.

LJ: They were wonderful and just like that they've just been converting.

MR: So they subscribe but now they're going to access it —

LJ: Online.

MR: Online.

LJ: Yeah. And so the first online issue came out this last week. I'd wanted to do it by the first but I had to convert so many people plus we re-formatted *The Rag* from a tabloid to an 8–1/2 by 11 so that they can read it and print it easily, and they can read it easier on the screen and they can print it off. I mean you can print off a tabloid on 8–1/2 by 11 but the type is this itsy bitsy you know. So we reformatted it plus I can use the color. So that was good. And then also we redesigned the website. So I've actually been doing all-nighters since I said I'm going to put out the last issue in October. Well and then also I downsized the office by two-thirds. So I haven't gotten any sleep yet, that's why I took a nap this afternoon. So it's just plugging away, and then the on-line distributor had to set certain things in motion while we did this conversion. So it actually, the first one was delivered to subscribers on Wednesday. And I talked to my sister who is monitoring all of this back home in Minnesota and she said wow, people love it. They're finding it easy to download and they love the color.

MR: How many subscribers do you have?

LJ: Well at the time that I had the print publication it was somewhere in the neighborhood of 36 hundred. But the pass along rate is triple that, easily. So we always figured that the readership was between 12 and 15 thousand people. There's always a very good response to advertising for instance, and they are people that aren't subscribers. Because a lot of the advertisers are festival producers and they would say at a festival, "How many of you came here because of *The Mississippi Rag?*" and people are waving their hands, and they're not necessarily subscribers.

MR: I was going to ask what your relationship is with the jazz parties and the jazz festivals.

LJ: They advertise quite heavily. And I run free listings for them too.

MR: Oh good.

LJ: As well as jazz cruises. And I was amazed that when we were doing this conversion to the emails, a lot of the people that I talked to, the older people, said, "Well I'm going to

convert because I can't live without your listings. I go on a jazz cruise every year." And I thought where is this money coming from, you know? Or, "I go to eight festivals a year." And these are elderly people. And they are really spending money on jazz. One woman I talked to had been on 15 jazz cruises. It's astonishing. So they wanted to convert because they wanted the listings in many cases. Other people love the historical articles. Everybody has their little favorite.

MR: How about the rest of your family? Are they — do they have the jazz bug as much as you?

LJ: Well in my own family, my kids are music buffs and they grew up with the music. My son was six when I started *The Rag*, my daughter was three. So they were kind of mascots for the Hall Brothers Jazz Band at the Emporium of Jazz and we had musicians staying with us and they heard that music all the time. But my own tastes are extremely eclectic and my first husband, it was the same thing. We liked everything. And so my kids were exposed to every kind of music, really. And my daughter ended up being a music teacher. She teaches middle school in Chicago and she teaches music, and her major was — well actually I guess it ended up being education, but she had a very strong major, almost a major in music performance. But then she decided she could affect more people with teaching than she could with performance so she went into teaching. But they grew up with that. And my second husband, Will, has been involved with jazz his whole life. So it's very much of a musical family in that everybody in my family has worked for *The Rag*. Everyone. Everyone — my kids have, my nieces, my nephews, my sisters, Will has written — Will wrote for the very first issue of *The Rag*, he writes a regular column now. My ex-husband worked for me up until just two years ago when I started to convert to an electronic publication where he wasn't doing what we used to do, the old cut-and-paste layout. So Dennis, my first husband and I, would slap together the paper and take it to the printer. So about a couple of years back the printer said, "The camera department is closing down, it's got to be electronic," and so that also led to the idea of on-line if we were going to prepare PDF files we might as well put it on-line.

MR: Do you think you can affect the powers-that-be in the IAJE or take a part in that in any way?

LJ: Seriously?

MR: Yeah.

LJ: No.

MR: Well it would have been nice —

LJ: In a perfect world.

MR: Talking to Vince last night, I almost felt like saying how come you're not playing at this thing, you know? I mean it would have been, when I looked at the line-up of the concerts,

there's a lot of great stuff here but it would have been nice to have — now Jim Cullum made a big hit last year, okay? So why isn't there something like that again?

LJ: I was astonished that there wasn't anything at all. And Vince would be — I mean here he is local. Why wouldn't you hire Vince? And Dan Levinson is here. I mean there are some extremely good classic jazz players in town. Dave Oscault is another one and Dave is very knowledgeable about Louis Armstrong in particular and is part of the Satchmo Summerfest in New Orleans. He does seminars and lectures down there and he's a local musician here. He could have been part of this.

MR: I wonder if those people are promoting themselves as much as everybody else is, because the IAJE, you have to apply to do a clinic. Maybe in your case they tapped you.

LJ: Actually that's exactly what happened because —

MR: But I know in my case I have to submit and go through the whole screening process and all that.

LJ: And I think that what you have with the traditional players is a lot of them are just scraping by financially. And it's similar to my position with *The Rag* where now my husband now is a very accomplished publicist and has a career with that and he gets frustrated because I don't promote *The Rag*. But what happens is there is so much effort going into the product you simply have no brain left. After I produce the paper all I want to do is sleep. I mean your energy is with the product. In Vince's case for instance, or with a lot of the musicians, they're trying to come up with the charts, they're trying to get the right musicians, they're trying to find the time to rehearse to get to the gig, which doesn't pay very much money and just the whole process of performing takes so much energy, and they don't have the money to do the promotion. So if you don't start out with big money you're really stuck. And when I started *The Rag* I started with two hundred dollars. I mean who in their right mind starts a publication with two hundred dollars, which was borrowed from my insurance company. So it's a cash flow problem really. And if you're going to get a good publicist you've got to pay him decent money. And if you're going to even get flyers printed up that look professional, it costs money. And you say well okay, go out and borrow the money, well if you're a musician who's going to loan you money?

MR: You want to do what?

LJ: Well and when I started *The Rag* I went to the state arts board. "No, we don't fund publications." There's always that exception. Okay — Small Business Administration? Everything but publications. You can't get any money. You have to personally guarantee it, you can't borrow it as a business. That was what I found when I started. So you just bite the bullet and you dive in.

MR: Who's your biggest competition?

LJ: Oh there's a publication on the West Coast called *The American Rag* and that's — but it's really very oriented towards the West Coast and he's tried to expand it but it has a very different type of presentation from what I do. And so it's not really, I don't really consider it very serious competition except in terms of the advertising dollars, but his circulation never has been — I've always been at least fifty percent more in terms of circulation.

MR: Do you go to things like the annual Bix Beiderbecke festival yourself? Do you find any reason to go there to promote the paper?

LJ: In the early years of *The Rag* I used to go to — I would go to the Bix Fest, I would always go to the New Orleans festival and I would almost always go to the St. Louis ragtime Festival, and then sporadically I would go to other festivals. I've been to Sacramento and San Diego and some of the jazz parties. But because it's pretty much a one-woman shop putting out *The Rag*, I just found that (a) it was too expensive, and (b) the time that it would take to get ready to travel, to travel, come back, get settled in again and being a mother of two kids too, you know that's a complicating factor too, I would get too far behind. And it's just a tremendous amount of work to put out a monthly publication. So I would suffer from going to these other festivals. And what happened too is I had a lot of freelance writers who would say, "I'm going to go to the Bix Fest, do you want me to cover it?" Okay. It was cheaper for me to pay them for the photos and for the text than it was for me to go. And they did a good job. So it really has segued into more freelancers covering the festivals instead of me. But I did cover a lot of the early ones, I took my trusty Pentax and took lots of pictures.

MR: Do you ever find that you want to help some bands with some criticism?

LJ: Oh is that a tender topic. It's very dicey trying to do that, especially with reviews, those are really tricky. What I tend to do is if there's a band, and I have hundreds and hundreds of CDs sitting there to be reviewed, or records, and I mean it used to be records in the olden days or tapes in the olden days, now it's CDs, far more than there's ever space to review. And if a recording is really bad I won't assign it to somebody because it doesn't serve any purpose. Once in a while if there's a band — well I'll give you an example of musicians who are wonderful musicians who put out some sloppy records. Ralph Sutton was one of the most recorded musicians there ever was. And I dearly loved that man personally and as a musician. But Ralph tended to do the same repertoire. He just, I mean you could pretty much count on a recording coming out and it was going to have "Echo of Spring" and it was —

MR: Oh he did the same song over and over?

LJ: Yeah. And they were always good — "Honeysuckle Rose." So the trick was to point out to people that it wasn't a new repertoire that Ralph was doing even though this is a brand

new CD, what to expect from it. It's not that he ever played badly, because Ralph I think was just a wonderful musician. But there were some musicians who tended to do the same repertoire. So that was one problem in covering recordings. But there were always people who wanted to have the Ralph Sutton records no matter how many times he did "Honeysuckle Rose," it didn't matter, they were going to have 35 records with "Honeysuckle Rose" on them and that was fine with them. So I still felt like we had to cover it. With some of these bands, the band itself was good, the weak point was the vocal. That's — because there's a forgiveness factor if you're listening to a band live and somebody's singing but everybody's caught in the moment and it doesn't matter if they're a little off key.

MR: Yeah, maybe it's fun to watch too.

LJ: Right. And so you're part of the crowd. And what I try and do with some recordings is if it's a good band but the vocals are dicey I will sometimes say to the band you know it's really a good recording but it's kind of problematic because there are a few too many vocals and what sounds good live doesn't come across necessarily to somebody who's not familiar with the band and doesn't — because people will forgive anything if they know the band and they know the musicians.

MR: Yeah. They can picture it.

LJ: But what I try and tell bands is the people that are reading *The Rag* don't know you. They're going to judge your band based on what they hear on this recording. And if you're singing off-key or if there's something wrong with the vocal or if somebody is really hitting at least some clams on it, they aren't going to forgive you for that. They're going to resent paying money for that recording. But it's really dicey. Sometimes we'll run a review and sometimes I will get stuck with writing the review. And I've had some musicians who say to me, "You're right, we knew when we did this recording that it wasn't up to our standard." But they tried to slide it in. Other musicians get angry. And so you can't really predict what you're going to get. And I always make it clear that the reviews are subjective. I try and assign the review to somebody who already likes that genre of music and is knowledgeable. I'm not going to give a ragtime record to somebody who only likes big bands. I try and find somebody who's knowledgeable, but sometimes I get reviews back and I think oh my God, am I going to run this?

MR: I'll get a brick through my window.

LJ: That's right. Those reviews are just a headache. There's no easy way to run reviews.

MR: Do you have pockets in the country of where your subscribers are?

LJ: You know when I started *The Rag* I thought it was actually going to be just local and then up and down the Mississippi River. But when the first issue came out people mailed it to friends of theirs all over the country. So by the third issue *The Rag* was in 26 states. It

had subscribers in 26 states. And early on it established itself with maybe only one subscriber in Alaska but in all 50 states and it stayed that way so it's been in all 50 states and maybe 26 foreign countries. And that's not a lot in any one of those areas. The Chicago area has always been extraordinarily loyal, and New England. Those are very strong and loyal areas where they took to *The Rag* early on and have stayed with it. Very, very loyal, especially Chicago. It had been fantastic. But it really is quite amazing and when we switched to online I said to my sister well we'll probably have to change our thing about *The Rag* because we're probably not in 50 states and 26 countries anymore. And we started tallying it up and she said, you know what, we still really are. You know there's fewer, because we haven't done all the conversion, but she said it still really is international and so we're still maintaining that balance.

MR: Well just to wrap up, if someone came to this country and had no idea what traditional jazz was, and they thought well here's a source, what would you tell them? How would you define it?

LJ: Oh that's a mean question.

MR: I know it is.

LJ: How would I define it?

MR: Could you describe it?

LJ: No. Because I'm not a musician.

MR: Oh I bet you could if I really made you.

LJ: You're trying to now.

MR: Because you see sometimes non-musicians have much better descriptions of music than musicians do, because musicians want to put it into music terms, and music terms don't work for everybody unless they're fellow musicians.

LJ: Well do you know that actually I think the Europeans understand traditional jazz better than Americans do. They have a younger audience, they are — for the most part — more knowledgeable about the early artists than a lot of Americans. And if you go to the European jazz festivals you find everything from little kids to older people at these festivals. And you find young jazz bands. It's really quite remarkable. I think it's more a case of trying to educate the Americans as to what traditional jazz is, rather than the Europeans. And even, here's one for you, I got a letter, yeah it was a letter, from Vladivostok, from a radio station there because they wanted to give out Rag tee shirts as their promotion for their New Year's Eve promotion on the radio station. And the DJ said, he read *The Rag* regularly. I have no idea how. I mean they couldn't subscribe way back when, but he was familiar with it and he said that their audience, because where Vladivostok was, was Japan and China and this small area of Russia. And so we sent him

tee shirts and that was going to be their prime thing to send out as their promotion for their New Year's Eve party.

MR: Well people try, if they're really into it, they try hard and they figure out how to get what their passion is. Well it's been a pleasure talking to you. I appreciate that you did that clinic this morning. And I hope they can figure out a way to make some headway.

LJ: I do think that the traditional jazz community does need to be more proactive and submit the proposals and learn how to do it. The trick is, as I mentioned at the panel this morning, that the older generation doesn't want to bother with it because they're cutting out the festivals or they're kind of retiring from the scene, so it's going to have to be younger people. And the key is trying to convince the younger people to take that responsibility. And I don't know if that's going to happen.

MR: Okay. Well thanks for your time.

LJ: Well thank you very much.

MR: Okay.